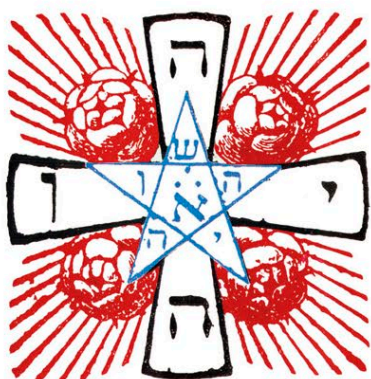




◀ Rose and cross

The symbol was designed by de Guaita in 1888. The Hebrew characters in the cross arms spell God; those in the pentagram arms spell Joshua. In the center is the letter "A" meaning Adam.

were drawn to non-Western faiths such as Buddhism and Hinduism, the focus of de Guaita's order was on spiritual enlightenment through a new understanding of Christian beliefs.

Symbolism and magic

De Guaita's society proved short-lived. Just as the Golden Dawn splintered in acrimony, so, after only two years, de Guaita's new order was riven in two. In 1890, Péladan, a devout Catholic, broke away not just from the Martinists but also from de Guaita. He established a rival body, the Ordre du Temple de la Rose + Croix, to revive the lost art of magic. Péladan's eccentricities alienated many, yet he possessed a genius for uniting figures of the Symbolist movement, who mingled spirituality with despair at the modern world in their work, and whose artistic views accorded with his own.

Péladan was both lampooned as a showman-fraud and admired as the authentic heart of late 19th-century French mysticism. He called himself "Super Magician" and "the Emperor" and opened one lecture with the words: "People of Nîmes, I have only to pronounce a certain formula for the earth to open and swallow you all." His fame peaked in 1892 when he launched a series of exhibitions of Symbolist work. Symbolist poets Stéphane Mallarmé and Paul Verlaine, composers Claude Debussy and Erik Satie, and artists such as Fernand Khnopff and Arnold Böcklin all came under Péladan's promotional wing.

► Salon de la Rose + Croix, 1892

Figures greet a new dawn in this poster for the first of six annual artistic exhibitions organized by Joséphin Péladan. The Salons celebrated his Rose + Croix order as well as the creative work of those involved in the Symbolist movement.

